



▼ Saffron gatherers

This Minoan fresco shows young girls harvesting saffron, potentially as part of a coming-of-age ritual. In Minoan art, white was used to represent the pale skin of women, while red was used for men.

sexuality and fertility, such as the breasts and hips. Some experts have suggested that these Venus figurines were fertility icons or goddess figures; others argue that the curvaceous bodies are not youthful and more likely represent older women, their size conveying prosperity and status in the community.

Over the years, experts have suggested that Neolithic societies were matriarchies, in which women served as head of the family

and played a leadership role. Venus figurines were given as evidence to support this theory, which argued that Neolithic peoples worshipped a range of mother goddesses. However, other archaeological evidence in Malta and elsewhere does not support this theory; the true purpose of these Venus figurines—and indeed, their true creators—can perhaps never be proved. Meanwhile, at the Neolithic site of Çatalhöyük in modern-

